WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

QATAR

Middle East

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Doha and Lusail	Capital and commercial centre; seat of government, the Qatar Financial Centre and most corporate headquarters, with real estate and financial services leading non-hydrocarbon growth in 2026	Financial services, real estate, professional services, tourism
Ras Laffan Industrial City	Qatar's LNG export hub with 77 million tonnes a year of capacity; two trains damaged in March 2026 are under repair while the rest of the complex has resumed exports	LNG, condensate, gas-to-liquids, energy services
North Field East and North Field South expansion	Flagship expansion lifting LNG capacity to 110 and then 126 million tonnes a year, with first new trains expected from 2027 and a further target of 142 million tonnes by 2030	Engineering, construction, oilfield services, shipping
Hamad Port and Umm Alhoul Free Zone	Main container port, with an adjacent free zone of about 32 km² for 100% foreign-owned companies in logistics and downstream industry	Logistics, maritime, polymers, downstream petrochemicals
Ras Bufontas Free Zone	Serviced free zone of about 4 km², 6 km from Hamad International Airport, offering pre-built facilities and smart customs	Aviation services, light manufacturing, emerging technology
Mesaieed Industrial City	Southern industrial base for gas-based downstream industry, drawing on competitively priced domestic feedstock	Petrochemicals, fertilisers, steel, aluminium
Education City and Qatar Science & Technology Park (QSTP)	Research and innovation cluster where QSTP-licensed companies benefit from tax exemption and customs-free imports	Technology, R&D, healthcare, digital services

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Invest Qatar (Investment Promotion Agency Qatar) provides one-stop facilitation, market intelligence and sector guidance for foreign investors
- Law No. 1 of 2019 on non-Qatari capital investment permits up to 100% foreign ownership in most sectors, with protection from expropriation, arbitration of disputes and customs exemptions for project equipment; banking, insurance, natural resources and commercial agencies remain subject to separate rules

- Qatar Financial Centre (QFC), an onshore platform with its own common-law-based regulator and court, and a 10% corporate tax rate, for financial, professional and technology businesses
- Qatar Free Zones Authority (QFZA) zones at Ras Bufontas and Umm Alhoul, offering 100% foreign ownership, renewable 20-year corporate tax holidays and zero customs duties
- Qatari riyal pegged to the US dollar at 3.64, with full capital repatriation and no personal income tax; the standard corporate tax rate outside the zones is 10%
- Public-private partnership framework (2020) for infrastructure and services, and joint ventures with QatarEnergy for energy-sector participation
- Law No. 16 of 2018 permitting non-Qatari freehold property ownership in designated areas and usufruct rights of up to 99 years elsewhere

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Qatar combines one of the world's largest sovereign balance sheets with a fast-growing pool of foreign business activity. In 2025 the country recorded 373 FDI projects, up 52% year on year, with $3.4 billion of capital expenditure and more than 15,000 new jobs, and rose 21 places to 12th in fDi Intelligence's Greenfield FDI Performance Index. More than 14,500 non-Qatari companies registered in 2025, and the Qatar Financial Centre onboarded 1,135 firms in the first half of 2026, up 37%, taking its total above 4,700. The non-hydrocarbon economy grew 2.6% in the second quarter of 2026, led by real estate (+11%), finance and insurance (+8.3%), trade (+6.9%) and construction (+5.5%). Up to 100% foreign ownership under Law No. 1 of 2019, tax-free zones and a dollar-pegged riyal underpin the investment case, and all three rating agencies affirmed Qatar's AA/Aa2 ratings with stable outlooks in 2026.

Qatar's main structural challenge is its reliance on LNG exports through the Strait of Hormuz, which the 2026 Iran war has brought into sharp focus. Iranian strikes in March halted Ras Laffan and damaged two LNG trains representing 17% of capacity, with repairs expected to take three to five years; shipping restrictions cut second-quarter LNG exports to under 2 million tonnes, against around 20 million a quarter in 2025. The IMF projects a 15.6% contraction in 2026, and the second-quarter budget deficit reached QR21.2 billion ($5.8 billion). Qatar has responded from a position of exceptional strength: sovereign net foreign assets of around 227% of GDP in 2025, official reserves up 10.85% year on year to QR223.4 billion in September, a restart of exports to about one-third of pre-war levels from September, and a leading role in mediating US–Iran talks. Fitch expects a strong rebound in 2027–28 as the North Field expansion comes on stream, creating opportunities in energy services, logistics and the wider non-hydrocarbon economy.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Strait of Hormuz shipping restrictions	Almost all LNG exports pass through the Strait, and LNG traffic remained around 80% below pre-war levels in early October 2026 despite a partial restart	Build shipping and supply-chain disruption scenarios into planning; Qatar's restart from September shows the system can scale up quickly as passage improves
Damage to LNG capacity	Strikes in March 2026 damaged Trains 4 and 6 (12.8 million tonnes a year, 17% of capacity), with repairs expected to take three to five years	The North Field expansion, adding capacity from 2027, will more than offset the loss; repair and expansion work offers openings for engineering and service firms
2026 economic contraction and fiscal deficit	The IMF projects GDP to contract 15.6% in 2026, and the second-quarter budget deficit was the widest since 2016	Sovereign assets far exceed debt and all three agencies affirmed AA/Aa2 ratings; Fitch expects a return to budget surplus by 2027
Regional security	Qatar's energy infrastructure was targeted during the 2026 Iran war, and US–Iran differences over Hormuz remain unresolved	Qatar's role as lead mediator gives it direct diplomatic channels; review insurance, force majeure clauses and business-continuity plans
Concentration on hydrocarbons	LNG and related products dominate exports and state revenue, so energy disruption weighs heavily on headline GDP	Non-hydrocarbon activity grew 2.6% in Q2 2026; finance, real estate, technology and logistics offer diversified exposure
Sector ownership rules and compliance	Banking, insurance, natural resources and	Structure through the QFC, the free zones

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	commercial agencies sit outside the 100% ownership regime, and Law No. 3 of 2023 strengthened penalties for nominee (concealment) arrangements	or properly licensed joint ventures, and take early local legal advice
Small domestic market	Qatar's population is small, limiting purely domestic consumer demand	Use Qatar as a well-capitalised regional base, with GCC customs-union access and the UK–GCC free trade agreement concluded in 2026

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Qatar's risk profile reflects an economy with world-class financial buffers that is managing a large but external shock. The 2026 Iran war halted LNG production in March, damaged 17% of export capacity and has kept Strait of Hormuz traffic well below normal, producing a sharp but temporary fall in output and a widening budget deficit. The fundamentals beneath this remain strong: sovereign net foreign assets of over twice GDP, rising official reserves, a credible dollar peg, AA/Aa2 ratings affirmed with stable outlooks by all three agencies, and a non-hydrocarbon economy that has kept growing. Exports restarted in September at about one-third of pre-war levels, and the North Field expansion is set to lift capacity well above pre-war levels from 2027. Investors should conduct thorough security, insurance and shipping due diligence and follow the Qatar-mediated US–Iran talks closely, while recognising that Qatar is well placed to lead the regional recovery once passage through Hormuz normalises.

MARKET ACCESS

Qatar is a member of the Gulf Cooperation Council customs union and the Greater Arab Free Trade Area, a WTO member since 1996, and a party to the UK–GCC free trade agreement concluded in 2026. Its LNG is sold mainly under long-term contracts to Asian buyers, including China, India, South Korea and Japan, and to European customers such as Italy and Belgium, while QatarEnergy's 18 million tonne Golden Pass LNG joint venture in the United States, whose first train began production in March 2026, adds an export platform outside the Gulf. Hamad Port and Hamad International Airport provide container and air-cargo connectivity, and Qatar is using ship-to-ship transfers in the Gulf of Oman and Red Sea routing to keep cargoes moving. This combination of GCC integration, global energy relationships and an international supply portfolio gives Qatar a resilient market access profile that will strengthen further as shipping normalises.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Amiri Diwan (Emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani)	Sets national strategy and economic policy and leads Qatar's diplomatic and mediation role in the region	Primary reference point for understanding Qatar's strategic direction and partnerships
Invest Qatar (Investment Promotion Agency Qatar)	National investment promotion agency; principal facilitation body for foreign investors	Standard first point of contact for market entry, incentives and sector guidance
Qatar Central Bank	Monetary and banking regulator; maintains the riyal's dollar peg and moved rates in line with the Fed in September 2026, with the deposit rate at 4.10%	Relevant for banking licences, currency and financing conditions
QatarEnergy	State energy company operating Ras Laffan and the North Field expansion, and the counterpart for all upstream and LNG partnerships	Essential partner for energy, engineering and energy-services engagement
Qatar Investment Authority (QIA)	Sovereign wealth fund and one of the world's largest institutional investors, with major holdings in the UK, US, Europe and Asia	Key co-investment partner and source of capital for international ventures
Qatar Financial Centre (QFC)	Onshore business and financial platform	Preferred structuring venue for financial,

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	with its own regulator and common-law-based court, hosting over 4,700 firms	professional and technology businesses
Qatar Free Zones Authority (QFZA)	Licenses and operates the Ras Bufontas and Umm Alhoul free zones	Key counterpart for tax-free manufacturing, logistics and technology operations

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Qatar Chamber is the principal domestic business association, alongside the American Chamber of Commerce in Qatar and other national business groups representing Western and Asian investors. Invest Qatar runs regular investor outreach and sector events, and the Qatar Economic Forum, Powered by Bloomberg, organised with the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, and Web Summit Qatar, which drew around 2,300 business licensing applications to the QFC in 2026, are leading networking platforms. Qatar Development Bank supports local small and medium-sized enterprises and is a useful partner for supply-chain and localisation projects. International energy companies with stakes at Ras Laffan and in the North Field expansion maintain substantial in-country presence and are a valuable source of practical intelligence on energy logistics.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Qatar suits investors seeking a well-capitalised, AA-rated Gulf base with long-term growth anchored in the world's largest LNG expansion programme: energy-services, engineering and construction firms positioned for the North Field expansion and Ras Laffan repairs; financial-services, fintech and professional-services firms using the QFC's common-law platform; technology and media companies drawn by QSTP and the QFC's fast-growing technology cluster; and logistics and downstream manufacturing investors using the tax-free Umm Alhoul and Ras Bufontas zones. Investors with shipping or export exposure should build Hormuz disruption scenarios into planning, while those focused on the domestic and services economy benefit from continued non-hydrocarbon growth.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage Invest Qatar and confirm the right entry vehicle
Open dialogue with the investment promotion agency to compare onshore ownership under Law No. 1 of 2019 with the QFC and free-zone regimes for your sector.

STEP 2: Evaluate QFC or free-zone structuring
Use the QFC's common-law framework for financial and professional services, or the QFZA zones for tax-free manufacturing, logistics and technology operations.

STEP 3: Position for the North Field expansion and recovery
Map supply-chain and service opportunities with QatarEnergy and its international partners as new capacity comes on stream from 2027 and damaged trains are repaired.

STEP 4: Build Hormuz and security scenarios into planning
Review shipping routes, insurance cover and force majeure terms, and track the Qatar-mediated US–Iran talks that will shape the pace of normalisation.

STEP 5: Explore co-investment with Qatari capital
Approach QIA and other Qatari investors for partnerships and co-investment, particularly for projects linked to the UK, GCC and wider international markets.